

The entrance of the Vadakkunnathan temple in Thrissur, said to be the first temple established in Kerala by Parashurama, built in classic Keralan architectural style, with tiled roofs and steep-sloped eaves.

The first Westerner to take note of this Malabari creation myth and the curious caste system that went with it was Johannes Nieuhof, an employee in the service of the Dutch VOC who took part in the assaults on Quilon and Cranganore (Kodungallur) over the winter of 1662–3 which finally broke the power of the Portuguese in the East Indies. Nieuhof stayed on as the VOC's local representative and to administer the pearl fishery at Tuticorin. One of his first duties was to negotiate a new trade agreement with the Rani of Quilon, which gave him the opportunity to observe the local culture at first hand.

'She had a guard of about 700 soldiers about her all clad after the Malabar fashion,' Nieuhof wrote in an account first published in Dutch and then half a century later in English as *Mr. John Nieuhof's Remarkable Voyages and Travels to the East Indies* (1732), 'the Queen's attirement being no more than a piece of calico wrapt round her middle, the upper part of her body appearing for the most part naked,